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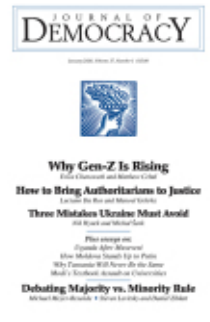
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UGANDA AFTER MUSEVENI

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In late May 2025, Ugandans witnessed something unprecedented in their country's history: President Yoweri Museveni and his wife, First Lady Janet Museveni, publicly asked them for forgiveness for any mistakes made during President Museveni's four decades in power. The president acknowledged errors committed by himself, his agents, and his party, while Janet Museveni described the occasion as both a "transition period" and a "destiny-defining moment."

Although neither the president nor his wife offered specifics, their remarks were widely interpreted as a tacit admission of uncertainty about Uganda's future once Yoweri Museveni—who is now 81, though some unofficial accounts claim he is older—no longer holds office. He is running for another five-year term in the January 2026 general election, but the comments that he and his wife made in May 2025 suggested an awareness at the highest levels of the regime that the political order could be headed for instability once he is gone.

Tellingly, Museveni directed his apology in particular to the Baganda, Uganda's largest ethnic group. Comprising 16.5 percent of the country's 46 million people and predominating in Central Uganda, they have long felt sidelined under the rule of a president who hails from Western Uganda.¹ The timing of the Musevenis' apology was telling: Just days prior, the couple's eldest child, 51-year-old armed-forces chief General Muhoozi Kainerugaba, had been on social media threatening to torture the oppositionist Eddie Mutwe, himself a member of the Baganda, vowing to "teach him Runyankole"—the language of Museveni's own Banyankole community, which makes up about a tenth of the national populace—"in my basement." The juxtaposition of an official apology with dire threats conveyed less a moment of reconciliation than a regime increasingly uncertain of its footing.

These developments underscore the Museveni system's fragility and volatility, highlighting the contradictions of a political order that is desperately seeking to stage-manage a smooth transition but exposing its own brittleness—and the risks of post-Museveni disorder—in the process.

The events of May 2025 are therefore emblematic of a deeper structural tension within the regime. The system that Museveni built around extreme personalization, militarization, and informal patronage is now badly stressed. Under an aged president, key decisions increasingly go unmade amid bureaucratic congestion and sketchy access to the leader. At the same time, presidential relatives and above all Muhoozi are consolidating authority and acting without much oversight, reinforcing patterns of power concentration and exclusion. His growing control over the army, combined with the decline in effective oversight from other senior elites, signals a shift in the internal balance of power.

The specter of elite fragmentation and heightened tensions haunts this “late Museveni regime” with its mix of militarization, ethnic power concentration, and unchecked repression. The regime's capacity for self-correction has eroded as key ministries and institutions become sluggish and sclerotic under an easily fatigued chief executive and informal actors make decisions outside normal channels. International partners such as the United States and the European Union, meanwhile, continue a “business as usual” approach that ranks stability and strategic alliances ahead of governance concerns. The beneficiary is Muhoozi, whose growing power raises profound questions about the trajectory that Uganda's political order will follow in the years ahead.

Over the last five years, building on research that I have been carrying out in Uganda since 2004, I have conducted about 250 interviews (either online or in Kampala) with government officials, businesspeople, journalists both foreign and Ugandan, diplomats, academics, and civil society activists. The insights gained from these conversations underlie the present analysis.

The personalization of power has long been among the Museveni regime's defining features. President Museveni's direct involvement and even micromanagement have long been staples of governance. There are many examples that illustrate his penchant for acting as the final or even sole authority on any issue or dispute. He has often intervened in matters of public administration and the implementation of specific policies.² Yet the current moment is marked by a paradox: On the one hand, the personalization of power faces growing strain; on the other, power is being concentrated more tightly than ever within a small circle of individuals.

The Unraveling of the Personalized Regime

Personalized rule requires a physically capable ruler—a point that is now much discussed in Uganda. Museveni came to power in his early

forties, having won a six-year guerrilla war in which he had led the National Resistance Movement (NRM) against the Milton Obote regime. Museveni was long known for presidential workdays that began early and ran late. He dealt with an endless range of topics, from minor land disputes to policies affecting motorcyclists and informal traders. Little proved too trivial for his attention.

That image has changed. Questions about the octogenarian chief executive's fitness have moved from private speculation to public discourse. This has become apparent during the current election campaign, as he travels and speaks far less than he used to. In early October, he abruptly canceled several rallies, citing "state duties." That explanation fooled no one. Subsequent breaks from his campaign only intensified speculation about fatigue and declining health.³

The regime has responded with deliberate public performances of presidential vitality. After officially winning the NRM nomination in late September, Museveni jogged down a red carpet to signal vigor and decisiveness. Instead of reassuring the public, however, the gesture only seemed to amplify concerns by showcasing how much energy he had to spend trying to prove that he still has energy.

Inside sources say that Museveni's current working hours have shrunk to six or eight per day. That is impressive for an octogenarian, but such a truncated (by Museveni standards) workday is not sufficient to keep the personalized system running smoothly. Matters pile up awaiting resolution, and "face time" with the president is difficult or even impossible to attain. Ugandan officials and foreign diplomats whom I interviewed told me of a case in which a matter involving a European country could not be settled because this required the president's in-person approval but no meeting with him could be arranged. Worse still, there are numerous reports that those who influence Museveni's schedule have become likelier to demand bribes in return for spaces on his calendar (with meetings not necessarily happening even then).

Tellingly, the official X account of the presidential office posted on 13 August 2025, "Please, do not pay to see me!"⁴ This public admission was a first, and suggests a worsening problem, namely that gatekeepers are operating beyond Museveni's control. Along with declining stamina has come a narrowing scope of interest. There are reports of people who are about to see him being coached to avoid anything potentially confrontational while sticking to preferred presidential subjects such as ideology.⁵

In practice, decisions that Museveni used to make himself are now being outsourced to a small group of his relatives and longtime associates. The NRM (which became the ruling party after Museveni won the war) was a "big tent" that added and coopted traditional and established elites into government and other key circles. This not only broadened the regime's legitimacy but also distributed political opportunities across different constituencies.

Over the years, however, many older elite figures retired, were pushed out, or defected, and politicians whose careers hinged entirely on relations with Museveni took their places. A key moment came when

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Amama Mbabazi, long a close ally of Museveni, challenged him in the 2016 presidential election. Museveni cruised to victory that year, but his wariness regarding independent power bases and political threats kicked into overdrive with Mbabazi’s defection. Cabinet purges saw Museveni dependents replacing any figures deemed too powerful.

Museveni himself described his 2021 cabinet as one of “fishermen,” a reference to the way Jesus chose as apostles people from that occupation rather than learned elites. Prime Minister Robinah Nabbanja, chosen in 2021, epitomizes this loyalty to Museveni. She has no following of her own, enjoys limited control over the cabinet, and devotes many lines in her public speeches to extravagant praise of the president.

With formal political offices weakened, real power has migrated into the informal realm of Uganda’s longstanding “shadow state.” Over time, this inner circle has shrunk, going from the broader elite of Western Uganda to the Banyankole ethnic group, then its Bahima subgroup, and now, increasingly, the president’s close relatives. The first family, long influential, looms larger than ever.

At its center is retired general Salim Saleh (b. 1960), Museveni’s half-brother. He holds no formal post but is widely seen as the de facto vice- or even co-president. From an original base in the security sector, his reach extends to politics and the economy, backed by a “shadow cabinet” in Gulu (Northern Uganda) that advises him on a range of issues. Every day in that town more than three-hundred kilometers from Kampala, Saleh hosts EU ambassadors, foreign presidents, government ministers, and representatives of armed groups. Natasha Karugire, Museveni’s eldest daughter, manages the presidential schedule.

Odrek Rwabwogo, the husband of second daughter Patience, exerts considerable sway over trade and economic policy. The First Lady is education minister and an influential figure within the NRM and the government. And as noted, Muhoozi commands the armed forces and is a key political actor in his own right. Outside this inner circle, a wider coterie of individuals with no formal posts makes political and financial hay from privileged access to Museveni and his family. Parties to business or land disputes will pay for the help of those “close to the throne.”

This ambiguous process, taking place at the intersection of reduced

personalization and increasingly concentrated power, gums up ministries' decisionmaking by making it hinge on go-aheads from a handful of hard-to-reach individuals. Kampala's *Daily Monitor* newspaper has recounted how the foreign ministry, to take one example, finds itself adrift amid a "general lack of direction bordering on a 'diplomatic vacuum.'"⁶ Foreign diplomats in the capital confirm the reality of urgent situations to which ministry officials can provide no answer. Museveni created this "paralysis below" dynamic with his top-down style, and as he has slowed with age it has only gotten worse. A Ugandan diplomat described ministry business to me as often "stuck" and "laying around" pending word "from above" that seldom comes in timely fashion.

The Muhoozi Project and Its Discontents

During his rapid rise through army ranks, General Muhoozi transformed the Presidential Guard Brigade into the Special Forces Command (SFC)—an elite unit responsible for presidential security and widely regarded as an "army within the army." He was made land-forces chief in 2021 and head of the entire military three years after that. He is widely viewed as a potential successor to his father, and is not shy about mentioning this. Looking ahead to the general election slated for 15 January 2026, Muhoozi in 2022 staged a nationwide political campaign under the guise of a series of lavish "birthday celebrations" for himself. Then he launched the Patriotic League of Uganda, a precursor political party. Although he eventually announced that he was backing his father for another term and would not run in 2026, he still bills himself on social media as Uganda's next president.

Among those made uneasy by the senior presidential scion's naked ambition are the older generations of army figures, particularly the "historicals"—grizzled senior soldiers who fought alongside Museveni in the 1980s' Bush War. This schism broke into the open in 2013, when General David "Tinyefuza" Sejusa called for a probe touching on the "Muhoozi project," a plan to rush the offspring to the top of the army that included an alleged scheme to assassinate high-ranking officers believed to be opposed to his rise.⁷ The *Daily Monitor* and its two radio stations faced a ten-day closure for publishing Gen. Sejusa's letter. The discomfiture of high-level NRM veterans had several sources. Muhoozi's meteoric ascent not only reflected favoritism, but also unsettled loyalties within the military and the ruling party by drawing younger cohorts toward him and away from older leaders. Those who formed their ideals decades ago amid liberation warfare find the notion of a tiny elite arranging a dynastic succession distasteful—all the more so when the heir apparent is given to bold and often provocative use of social media. In recent years, one of these "historicals," retired general

and current interior minister Kahinda Otafiire, has become the most vocal Muhoozi critic.

These tensions manifested themselves in public in June 2022, when the deputy chief of the armed forces, General Peter Elwelu, put the army on highest alert and froze all troop and equipment movements. Such a call is very rare and did not even happen when Kampala was hit by a string of (suspected) Islamist suicide bombings in October and November 2021. Muhoozi, who was top officer of the land forces at the time and thus below Elwelu in the chain of command, instructed his troops to ignore this order. Each camp accused the other of plotting a coup.⁸ While the precise reasons for this standoff remain undisclosed, it revealed the poor state of relations between Muhoozi and the military's old guard.

In March 2024, Muhoozi became chief of the entire military and began reshuffling the senior officer corps. Until that time, such promotions and demotions had always been made by President Museveni himself, not a serving officer or cabinet official. For Muhoozi to decree such personnel moves (and in a fairly opaque fashion) showed both that power had shifted and that he was determined to consolidate the change by placing his own associates in strategic jobs. At the same time, he made retirement terms more generous to help head off dissent, reward loyalty, and boost his popularity across the forces.

Muhoozi has leveraged his position to sideline critics, often pushing them into retirement. The most prominent example was Gen. Elwelu. He was dropped from active duty in March 2024, and in August 2025 was formally sent into early retirement along with several other senior officers. In December 2024, Muhoozi publicly disparaged him as a "buffoon" and threatened to arrest him.⁹ A former personal aide to Museveni, Elwelu had been trusted with sensitive tasks, such as leading soldiers and police into the foothills of the Ruwenzori Mountains to suppress a royalist movement in 2016—an operation that led to more than a hundred deaths in what Human Rights Watch calls a massacre.¹⁰

Muhoozi's power base is the SFC, which he has commanded since its start. This formation operates as a parallel military, with not only ground troops but aircraft and an intelligence-gathering arm. The SFC chain of command runs directly from the president, bypassing the defense ministry and the uniformed head of the military.

Although its exact strength remains unknown, the SFC has been growing in numbers and funding so that its size and cost now appear to rival those of the army and air force. Muhoozi is generally credited with upgrades in the training and equipment of what is billed as the Ugandan military's elite unit. To fill its ranks, he favors loyalists, especially those with ties to the first family or its home region of Western Uganda. This has given the SFC an outspoken ethnic identity aligned with the Bahima (the ethnic subgroup of the Banyankole people to which Museveni belongs). Not only the president but key pieces

of physical infrastructure such as oil fields and airports are guarded by SFC personnel.

When the regime cracked down on the opposition during the run-up to the January 2021 presidential election, the SFC played a key role. Its troops operate in neighboring countries as well, raising Muhoozi's profile. Muhoozi shaped the SFC into a loyal elite force, and it has boosted his rise within the state, giving him a "praetorian guard" and a vehicle for his political aspirations.¹¹ In mid-2025, a new law brought the SFC under the formal command of the military—but with Muhoozi as military chief, one could argue that the military is now under the SFC.

The silence surrounding Muhoozi is a sign of his stature: The historicals no longer talk about him in public, and one interviewee described him to me as "too colossal to critique." Figures who once could mediate or manage conflicts involving him—Salim Saleh, for instance—no longer have that kind of pull.¹²

Another sign is Muhoozi's provocative tweeting. In October 2022, he bragged online that "my army" could take Nairobi in less than two weeks. President Museveni officially apologized to Kenya for the comment, and Muhoozi briefly stopped tweeting. The May 2025 tweets about Eddie Mutwe featured Muhoozi's claim that he was keeping the oppositionist "in my basement," which was widely understood as an allusion to torture.¹³ Then there were threats to hang or behead other opposition figures such as presidential candidates Bobi Wine (to whom Eddie Mutwe has been a bodyguard and close ally) and Kizza Besigye. Officials who question Muhoozi's statements or strategy are swiftly denounced. When former intelligence chief and Salim Saleh advisor David Pulkol raised concerns about how Muhoozi had been posting tweets during a meeting with EU ambassadors, Muhoozi called him a "habitual traitor" who "will have nowhere to hide."¹⁴

Militarization and Violence

All this must be seen in the context of the increasing militarization of both state and society. Militarization is nothing new under Museveni, but in recent years it has intensified. The military's role in civilian institutions is expanding. The national immigration authority and the interior ministry are now run by military officers. Key police posts have increasingly been filled by them as well. A 2025 legal change allows military courts to try civilians, undercutting civilian authority and making politically motivated prosecutions more likely.

Military involvement in the civilian economy is growing as well. The business wing of the armed forces, the National Enterprise Corporation is not only a big player in construction and road building, but does everything from developing farmland to hiring out security guards to bottling water.

Freer use of violence is evident as well. In May 2025 and again in early June, the SFC raided a police station. In the first raid, near Kampala, soldiers physically assaulted everyone present.¹⁵ In a separate May incident, commandos snatched a senior police official, Charles Twiine, who disappeared for a week before being brought before a court.¹⁶ This was around the time when Muhoozi was tweeting about holding a man in his basement, claiming that he had turned the military into a “killing machine,”¹⁷ and threatening to kill Bobi Wine and Kizza Besigye.¹⁸

Whereas previous episodes of brutal tweeting may have had consequences—in October 2022, Muhoozi lost his post as land-forces commander after his tweets about seizing Nairobi—this is no longer the case. Officials might express frustration and fear in private, but neither President Museveni, his party, nor any cabinet minister has said a word in public. Early 2025 did see efforts to call Muhoozi before Parliament, but he responded by calling legislators “clowns” and threatening to arrest them.

While violence has long marred Ugandan election seasons, the years since 2020 have seen a major escalation. During the November 2020 protests over Bobi Wine’s arrest ahead of the January 2021 voting for president, security forces killed at least 54 people. During the same election period, about thirteen-hundred others (mostly members of Wine’s National Unity Party or NUP) were detained.¹⁹ Many were abducted and then tortured, beaten, or otherwise abused.²⁰ More recently, between January and June 2025, security services raided NUP headquarters three times, injuring and arresting numerous party members.²¹ The message was clear: No one protesting the current regime is safe.

As repression has mounted, so have flaws in the electoral process.²² Civil society groups have been driven out of politics, leaving online activists as the only elements of civil society (as distinguished from opposition political parties and politicians such as the NUP and Wine) who are challenging the regime. Decades of personalization, combined with pervasive fear and repression, have silenced debate within the ruling party. Militarization and the concentration of power proceed without restraint or limit.

The January 2026 election is being handled like a military exercise rather than a democratic process. After the MP for Kawempe North died in office, the January 2025 by-election to fill the seat saw journalists and opposition members brutally attacked. Twenty journalists faced assault or arrest as masked security agents smashed or seized their equipment. This was unprecedented even by Ugandan standards.²³ And although the official campaign started off quietly, it quickly returned to old patterns: From November on, the security forces arrested opposition members in large numbers. No account of Uganda’s politics can be complete if it ignores ethnic distinctions. As noted above, the SFC has a nearly monoethnic composition. The informal concentration of

power similarly follows ethnic lines. The Museveni regime has long tended to focus authority in people from the president's own region and ethnic group.²⁴ As decisions have been made ever less formally, power has flowed to a small and ethnically homogeneous group while other regions and ethnic groups receive no more than token representation and simmer in frustration.

Muhoozi openly positions himself as the promoter and protector of the Bahima and Banyarwanda. He glorifies the Ugandan Bahima and claims that within the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) the "Bahima/Batutsi"²⁵ are endangered. This messaging strengthens his base, but at the cost of heightening intercommunal tensions. To many, his rise and relative impunity signal the emergence of an ethnomilitary dynasty.

When Muhoozi reveled in his mistreatment of Eddie Mutwe, who belongs to the Baganda people, and wrote of teaching him Runyankole—the language of the Banyankole—it was a public display of violent Banyankole supremacy both in general and over the Baganda in particular. This rhetoric has understandably caused concern among people from Western Uganda, who perceive themselves as becoming potential targets and see Muhoozi's messaging as endangering their position. While the immediate beneficiaries form a small political-military elite, the perception has grown that everyone from Western Uganda (including those with no ties to the president's specific home region) is profiting from the current system.

Since the Baganda are the country's largest single ethnic group, including them had been crucial to Museveni's "big tent" strategy. He gave government posts to Baganda individuals and restored to their traditional Buganda kingdom its cultural (though not political) recognition. Nevertheless, relations have frayed during Museveni's long years in power, with mistrust bursting into open conflict during the September 2009 "Buganda riots" that cost more than forty lives. The November 2020 campaign-season riots and the recent political abductions all occurred in Buganda, which adds to the sense of ethnic foreboding among the non-Banyankole. Museveni himself has tried to paint Bobi Wine and the NUP as a Baganda party, drawing on historical distrust of Buganda in other parts of the country. This has ramped up ethnic tensions further.

After Museveni

The January 2026 election crystallizes the core dilemma of Uganda's late-Museveni moment: a political system performing the rituals of democratic competition while preparing for an uncertain succession. The outcome is predetermined—Yoweri Museveni will secure a ninth term—but the conduct of the campaign underscores the regime's anxiety about what will follow if and when an 81-year-old president leaves the stage.

As Muhoozi moves to consolidate power, maneuvering inside the ruling party has become the real means of contestation. In practice, the 2026 election is less as a search for public legitimacy than a managed security operation aimed at containing dissent, especially among the

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young, urban “ghetto youth” (often Baganda) whose frustration the regime has tried to blunt by coercing them, trying to coopt them, and offering them patronage. The August 2025 elections for the NRM’s highest decisionmaking organ, its Central Executive Committee, made this dynamic explicit. A seat on this committee offers proximity to Museveni and access to the favors and opportunities that sustain the system. The contest became a high-stakes intra-NRM struggle over positioning

in a post-Museveni order.²⁶ Marked by extensive bribery and factional bargaining, these elections revealed that succession politics now drive the regime more than electoral competition does: Uganda’s 2026 polls calibrate elite interests rather than chart a democratic future.

The key question therefore remains: After President Museveni passes from the scene, what will happen? The 1995 Constitution calls for the vice-president to assume the presidency pending elections that must be held within six months. With so many government decisions now made informally, however, it is unlikely that formal rules will be strictly followed. Uganda has a personalized regime built up over decades at the expense of institutions, and the country has yet to see a peaceful transfer of power. When the incumbent on whom the polity has long been centered is gone, who or what will decide what is to come next? The answers, briefly, are the family, the army, the ethnic groups, and the neighbors.

The first family’s role will be crucial. Who will step forward? Will Muhoozi take the lead, and how might Salim Saleh react? Muhoozi has had social-media run-ins with his brother-in-law Odrek Rwabwogo; will they clash over the succession?

The military is more firmly under Muhoozi’s control than ever, but questions remain about how units outside his immediate remit will respond. The June 2022 standoff within the army has often been interpreted as an early sign of fissures. Will the SFC—Muhoozi’s most loyal cadre—face an army mutiny? Some analysts argue that Muhoozi’s opponents have resigned themselves to his dominance while others suggest that internal resistance persists, raising the possibility of fragmentation.

Third, ethnic considerations will loom large. Should another person from Western Uganda assume power, how will other regions and ethnic groups respond, particularly the Baganda? Ethnic tensions flaring into periodic violence have been a problem for years. The so-called Buganda riots broke out in Kampala in 2009 when the Buganda monarch—who is allowed a cultural but not a political role—wanted to visit a volatile area near the capital, but the government barred him. During the ensuing disorder, his angry supporters in the capital targeted individuals deemed Banyankole by appearance or accent. On 21 January 2021, the same day election results were announced, four buses from President Museveni’s home region were attacked in Kampala. More recently, the president’s public apology to the Baganda signaled that the regime grasps the seriousness of ethnic tensions, yet it remains uncertain how the country’s Baganda population will react if another Westerner accedes to the highest office.

Lastly, the reaction of regional powers, particularly President Paul Kagame’s government in Rwanda, will be significant. Muhoozi has cultivated close ties with Rwanda in recent years, consistently praising Kagame—whom he calls his “uncle”—and openly supporting the Rwandan-backed M23 rebels in the DRC. Relations between Uganda and Rwanda, and specifically between Museveni and Kagame, have historically oscillated between cooperation and mutual suspicion, with both countries at times accusing each other of undue political interference. Rwanda will undoubtedly watch any Ugandan transition with intense interest, potentially shaping its own response based on perceived threats or opportunities.

Together, these factors suggest that Uganda’s transition could take any number of forms ranging across a broad spectrum. In the worst case, a fractured army, ethnic violence, and negative involvement by regional actors could converge to cause profound instability. This alarming possibility worries many. Seasoned political commentator Charles Onyango-Obbo highlights the danger of a Somalia-style collapse in which military, ethnic, and regional actors clash.²⁷ Some warn of a Sudanese scenario, in which SFC-loyal forces clash with “regular” army elements. While the exact form of the transition remains unpredictable, the strong de-institutionalization, militarization, and personalization of power in Uganda paint a particularly concerning picture of the country’s immediate political future.

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